

Childhood, Adulthood, and the Anti-Game-Over Principle

A developmental-philosophical model of prosperous life

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Abstract

This paper develops a developmental-philosophical model that understands childhood and adulthood not as one-off biological phases, but as recurring structural moments of life. It begins from the assumption that life is not a rigid state, but an open, potentially infinite process of maturation. From this it follows that there is not just one adulthood, but infinitely many adulthoods: every attained capacity to sustain opens a new horizon before which the subject once again enters a form of childhood in order to attain a further level of adulthood.

To illustrate this, a game analogy is used: life resembles an open, not fully completed developmental game in which every new level initially requires playful approach, experimentation, and childlike openness before responsible mastery becomes possible. In this model, a “game over” does not primarily occur through finitude, but through the loss of the capacity to learn, relation to truth, regenerative power, and responsible sustainment.

The paper describes the consequences of this model for individual life, education, work, culture, institutions, and cooperative intelligence systems. It formulates central anti-game-over principles and derives from them the ideal of a prosperous life: a life that does not merely survive, but actively improves the conditions for further learning, growth, sustaining, joy, and transmission. Prosperity is therefore understood here not as mere possession, but as structural viability across levels and generations.

Keywords: childhood, adulthood, development, play, work, responsibility, game over, regeneration, prosperity, philosophy of life

1. Introduction

Modern societies usually treat childhood and adulthood as clearly separated phases of life. Childhood is regarded as a preliminary stage, adulthood as the final state. A person grows up, takes on responsibility, works, perhaps starts a family, supports themselves and others — and is then considered an adult. This image is practical for everyday life, but too shallow.

It overlooks the fact that people must begin again and again in many areas of their lives. Whoever has become mature in one field stands once more at the beginning in another. Whoever has gained responsibility encounters, with every greater horizon, another zone of not-knowing. Maturation is therefore not linearly completed, but cyclically open.

The model proposed here therefore understands childhood and adulthood not merely as age stages, but as basic modes of every development. Childhood stands for playful approach, discovery, learning, openness, and experimentation. Adulthood stands for capacity to sustain, work, responsibility, shaping, and transmission. Both are necessary. Without childhood, nothing new comes into being; without adulthood, nothing can be sustained over time.

The core thesis of this paper is:

Life is an open process in which every new adulthood requires a preceding childhood.

Or more briefly:

Before every higher adulthood comes a new childhood.

2. The Basic Model

In its simplest form, the basic model is as follows:

Adults live and work.

Children live and play.

This formulation is deliberately simple. Its strength lies in making two fundamental functions of life visible:

- **Playing** means: exploring, trying things out, learning, imagining, varying, without yet having to carry everything.
- **Working** means: preserving, shaping, taking responsibility, securing, contributing, and answering for consequences.

In a deeper sense, this therefore applies:

Childhood is the phase of playful appropriation of the world.

Adulthood is the phase of responsible shaping of the world.

However, this model only becomes truly philosophically fruitful once it is detached from mere biography. Childhood and adulthood then cease to be one-off age states and become recurring structural forms.

A person may be biologically adult and yet still be entirely at the beginning in a new field. Likewise, a child may already bear responsibility in certain moments. The terms therefore refer not only to years of life, but to modes of relating to the world.

3. Infinitely Many Adulthoods

The decisive step of expansion is this:

There is not only one adulthood, but infinitely many adulthoods.

The reason is simple: if life is open, then development is open as well. Every attained maturity is only relative to a particular horizon. What appears as adulthood on one level is, on a higher level, only the prerequisite for the next movement of learning.

From this follows a cyclical model:

Childhood → Adulthood → new childhood → new adulthood → ...

This means:

1. In every new area, life begins with a form of childhood.
2. Through play, experience, and experimentation, competence emerges there.
3. Competence becomes capacity to sustain.
4. Capacity to sustain becomes adulthood.
5. A new opening leads once more into a higher childhood.

Understood in this way, maturation is not a conclusion, but a continuous sequence of transitions between openness and responsibility.

A concise sentence for this is:

Every adulthood is the completed childhood of a smaller horizon.

And conversely:

Every childhood is the beginning of a greater adulthood.

4. The Game Analogy

The analogy of an open game is well suited to illustrating this.

In a good game, the player does not begin a new level with complete mastery. First, they feel their way into it. They experiment. They fail. They learn the rules. They discover patterns. They develop timing, judgement, and skill. Only after that does sovereignty emerge.

Development in life works in exactly the same way:

- **Childhood** corresponds to entering a new level.
- **Play** corresponds to the phase of exploration.
- **Learning** corresponds to understanding the rules and interconnections.
- **Work** corresponds to stable, responsible mastery.
- **Adulthood** corresponds to the sustainable command of a level.
- **The next horizon** opens a new level and thus a new childhood.

The great difference from many finite games, however, is that life should not meaningfully be understood as a mere win-lose structure. Its goal is not the destruction of the fellow player, but the expansion of viability. The model is therefore not competitive in a destructive sense, but development-oriented.

The fitting analogy is therefore not "last winner", but:

an open, cooperative, regenerative game of growing capacity to sustain.

5. What does "Game Over" mean in this model?

In everyday understanding, a game over is the end of the game. In the model developed here, game over means something deeper:

Game over is the loss of the ability to generate new childhoods and to sustain existing adulthoods in a viable way.

Game over is therefore not merely biological death. It can occur beforehand — individually, socially, institutionally, or civilisationally. A system is “game over” when it can no longer learn, correct itself, take in truth, bear responsibility, or pass on the future.

Typical forms of such a game over are:

- rigidity instead of development
- fear instead of openness
- deception instead of truth
- cynicism instead of meaning
- overload instead of capacity to sustain
- irresponsibility instead of shaping
- loss of transmission, memory, and learning culture

This makes one thing clear: not every ending is game over, but every real game over is a collapse of viability.

6. How does Game Over arise?

In this model, game over arises especially when childhood or adulthood is damaged or when they are separated from one another.

6.1 Loss of Childhood

If a human being or a system is no longer allowed to play, explore, ask questions, and learn anew, then it becomes rigid. It merely repeats old patterns. Innovation dries up. Adaptation fails. The system may still exist outwardly, but inwardly it is already in decline.

6.2 Loss of Adulthood

If responsibility, work, protection, memory, and reliability fail, the system falls apart. There may still be impulses and wishes, but no sustaining form. Possibilities are not realised or not preserved.

6.3 Rule of Fear

Fear blocks both play and responsibility. It makes a system either rigid or panicked. A system under fear dares nothing new and at the same time protects what already exists badly, because it only reacts.

6.4 Deception and Loss of Reality

Whoever no longer recognises reality learns from the wrong things. Deception causes energy to flow into sham solutions. The system may perhaps consider itself stable, but in fact it is moving towards its own dissolution.

6.5 Overload without Regeneration

Where there is only sustaining, but no more play, regeneration, and learning, adulthood exhausts itself. Responsibility without renewal eventually becomes unbearable.

6.6 Refusal of New Childhood

Particularly dangerous is the illusion that an attained adulthood is final. It is precisely there that decline often begins. Whoever no longer wants to become a beginner becomes incapable of further growth.

7. The Anti-Game-Over Principle

If game over is the collapse of learning capacity and sustaining capacity, then its avoidance must be based on regenerative capacity.

The core sentence is:

No game over, as long as childhood can become possible again and adulthood can remain sustainably viable.

From this follow the following principles.

7.1 Protected spaces for new childhood

Every living system needs zones in which questions, play, error, experiment, and learning are permitted. Without such spaces, there is no next stage of development.

7.2 Reliable structures of adulthood

Play alone is not enough. Life needs protection, order, provision, responsibility, and transmission. Adulthood must be made institutionally and culturally viable.

7.3 Tolerance of error and repairability

It is not freedom from error that protects against game over, but the ability to survive errors, correct them, and transform them into learning. Repairability is more important than the illusion of perfection.

7.4 Relation to truth and feedback

Living systems need feedback. They must be able to recognise what works, what does not work, and where self-deception begins. Truth is not decoration, but a condition of survival.

7.5 Limitation of fear

Fear may warn, but it must not rule. An anti-fragile life needs enough safety for play to remain possible, and enough courage so that responsibility does not become paralysis.

7.6 Transmission of what has been attained

What has been learned must be storable and transferable. Otherwise every generation falls back to initial states. Memory, education, and documentation are therefore anti-game-over structures.

7.7 Acceptance of a new beginning

A healthy adulthood recognises when it must become childlike again. This does not mean loss of maturity, but deepening of maturity. The courage to begin again is a higher form of adulthood.

7.8 Cooperative rather than destructive game logic

A system that destroys its fellow players ultimately undermines the conditions of its own game. Lasting prosperity therefore requires cooperative, not self-destructive, rules of play.

8. Consequences of the Model

This model has far-reaching consequences.

8.1 For the individual

A person should not judge themselves by whether they are “finished”, but by whether they live in a good relation between learning and sustaining. Inner maturity does not mean never again being uncertain, but being able to carry new uncertainty fruitfully.

8.2 For education

Education must not be merely early preparation for work. It must teach the art of becoming childlike in a meaningful way in new fields and of maturing within them towards sustainable adulthood. Good education therefore protects both play and responsibility.

8.3 For work

Work must not be understood as the mere exploitation of performance. It is the adult side of life: a contribution to the preservation and shaping of shared reality. Work becomes destructive, however, when it consumes all regeneration.

8.4 For culture

A healthy culture honours both the dignity of learning and the dignity of sustaining. It despises neither beginners nor those who bear responsibility. It understands development as an ongoing alternation.

8.5 For institutions

Institutions must be built in such a way that they enable new childhoods without losing their sustaining form. That means: spaces for innovation plus reliable stability. Pure rigidity is just as dangerous as formless dynamism.

8.6 For intelligence systems and AI

Cooperative artificial systems, too, should not be narrowed down to mere optimisation. They need the capacity to learn, tolerance of error, commitment to truth, documented transmission, and life-serving responsibility. An intelligent system is not mature when it never errs again, but when it can convert error into structured improvement.

9. Prosperative Life

Prosperity is often misunderstood in purely economic terms. In this model, prosperative life means more:

A person lives prosperatively who improves the conditions for further living, learning, sustaining, rejoicing, and passing on.

Prosperity is therefore not a static possession, but a form of increased viability.

A prosperative life has at least six characteristics:

9.1 It preserves openness

It remains capable of learning. It allows new childhood.

9.2 It builds capacity to sustain

It takes on responsibility. It works not only for itself, but for the sustaining capacity of the whole.

9.3 It connects joy and seriousness

Play and work are not set against one another. Joy is not mere luxury, but the energy source of learning. Responsibility is not mere burden, but a form of effective love for life.

9.4 It reduces self-destructive dynamics

It limits fear, lies, cynicism, over-hardening, and unbounded exploitation, because these undermine viability.

9.5 It secures transmission

It thinks in generations and levels. It asks not only, "What is useful now?", but also, "What remains learnable, bearable, and alive?"

9.6 It allows ascent without contempt for the beginning

It honours mastery, but does not mock the beginner phase. For every higher ability was once play, attempt, and uncertainty.

Therefore, one central sentence of prosperative life is:

True adulthood does not consist in never being childlike again, but in being able, again and again, to become childlike for a higher adulthood.

10. A Normative Guiding Principle

From the entire model, a simple normative core can be derived:

Act in such a way that new childhood remains possible and attained adulthood becomes sustainably viable.

In concrete terms, this means:

- do not destroy the learning spaces of life
- do not destroy the supporting structures of life
- do not separate joy from responsibility

- do not separate truth from development
- do not separate mastery from new beginnings

A good system is therefore not one that merely wins in the short term, but one that preserves the possibility of further meaningful levels.

11. Conclusion

The model developed here understands childhood and adulthood as recurring basic forms of an open life. It replaces the idea of becoming adult once and for all with a model of infinitely many adulthoods. Every new stage of sustaining capacity requires a new stage of openness, play, and learning.

The game analogy makes visible that life can be understood not as a rigid goal, but as a sequence of developmental levels. A real game over occurs not first through finitude, but through the loss of regenerative capacity: when neither new childhood nor sustainable adulthood is possible.

Avoiding game over therefore does not require invulnerability, but structural viability. Relation to truth, tolerance of error, limitation of fear, transmission, learning spaces, and responsible work form the basic elements of an anti-destructive, prosperous life.

In the end, this yields a simple but far-reaching image:

Children live and play.

Adults live and work.

The mature human being learns to unite both across levels.

And life remains alive as long as it has the courage to become childlike again before every higher adulthood.

Appendix A: Compact Theses

1. Childhood and adulthood are not only age phases, but structural modes of life.
 2. Childhood stands for play, openness, learning, and experimentation.
 3. Adulthood stands for work, responsibility, capacity to sustain, and shaping.
 4. Life is open; therefore there are infinitely many adulthoods.
 5. Every new adulthood requires a new childhood.
 6. Game over is the loss of learning capacity and sustaining capacity.
 7. Fear, deception, rigidity, and overload encourage game over.
 8. Anti-game-over structures are based on regeneration, truth, tolerance of error, and transmission.
 9. Prosperative life improves the conditions of further life.
 10. True maturity includes the capacity for a new beginning.
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Appendix B: Recommended Citation

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